Charmed by Chennai

Actor-musician Shruti Haasan spills the beans about what makes Chennai her favourite city

You've extensively travelled the world for both personal and professional reasons. Which is a city that you would keep going back to?

Chennai will always hold a soft spot in my heart. I was born there and studied until grade 11. I continue to come back for work commitments and my father lives here. It is home.

What is it about Chennai that you cherish the most?

I believe it is the city's balancing act between tradition and modernity. Whenever I think of Chennai, the ocean comes to mind. Whether it's Marina Beach or Elliot's Beach or even the East Coast Road...a lot of my childhood was spent around the sea. Near the Besant Nagar Beach, there was a skating rink where I would rollerblade with my friends. It was also very close to the Velankanni church, so it was an interesting mix of people and culture.

What are your top places to get a taste of Chennai?

Manjal is one of my all-time favourites for its selection of non-vegetarian food. I particularly love their crab lollipop and coin parotta and paya curry. At Junior Kuppanna, the mutton sukka is to die for, and Annalakshmi serves pure vegetarian food. Do try their thali.

What kind of a traveller are you?

I am an overpacker! Also, because I am an anxious person, I keep thinking what if I run out of clothes? For a five-day trip, I will carry 15 changes. But I am working towards packing light.

Some travel essentials that you swear by?

I always carry the correct adapters and plug points, especially when travelling internationally. I also stay up to date with the weather before I go, and pack accordingly. And I carry appropriate footwear.

–With Geetika Sachdev

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